

Rivers

A river is a natural channel of fresh water that flows across the Earth's surface. All rivers start in mountains or hills and flow down towards the sea or ocean, or into another large area of water. They may be short or flow for hundreds of kilometres.

Source

This is where a river starts, high up in the mountains. The source, or place where the river starts from, could be a spring or a lake, or even a melting glacier. A river can have more than one source.

Tributary

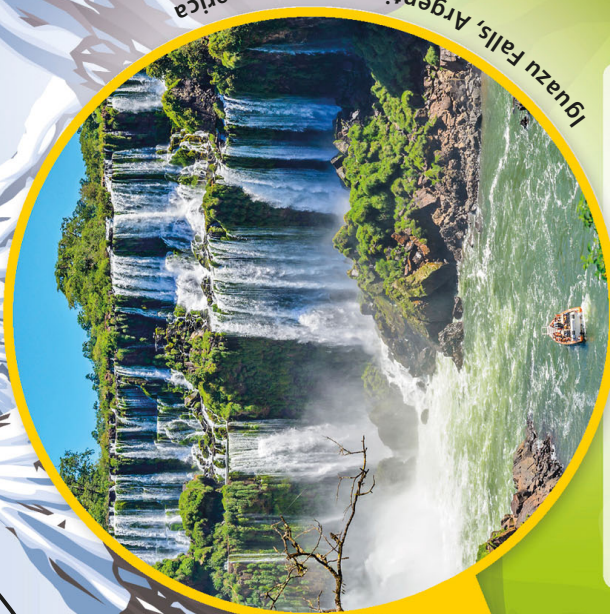
A stream or river that flows into a larger river, rather than directly to the sea, is called a tributary. Some large rivers have hundreds of tributaries!

V-shaped valley and gorge

Near its source, a river flows very fast. The rushing water wears away the surrounding rock. This widens and deepens the river channel, forming a gorge or V-shaped valley.

Waterfall

Rivers usually flow over a mixture of hard and soft rock. The force of the water will wear away more soft rock than harder rock. Where this happens, there may be a steep drop in the level of the riverbed, creating a waterfall.



Iguazu Falls, Argentina, South America

Fast-Flowing